

THE STORY OF MY LIFE
by Dosebai Cowasjee Jessawalla
SPEAKING TIGER
₹799; 344 pages

and you see Dosebai's domestic triumphs, squabbles and weekend jaunts. Read it a second time and you hear the clear voice remarking on narrow-mindedness and the treatment of women at the hands of men. "...the time has come for my sisters to demand with unmistakable voice their rights and privileges of which their selfish husbands have so long deprived them," she insists. It's this determination to reject hollow customs and injustices that make Dosebai and her story relevant even today. ■

Shabnam Minwalla

Early on in the story, there's a moment when the elderly professor (the antagonist) mishears Adil's 'Khala Ruhaba' as 'Allah hu Akbar'. Adil has been sent to the US from France because his mother fell foul of the headscarf police, and he in his anger met some boys in a mosque and said unassimilated things about French racism. Adil has no idea what hit him, and he soon finds out that the US is scarier than anything he encountered in Europe. Nevertheless, he is trusting and affectionate, which is his and Ruhaba's downfall.

This is not an easy book to read. It will excoriate you, but in a good way. You will close it feeling thankful that you don't have to live in a white-ruled country. Believe me, I've tried it. It's as bad as Sonora Jha says it is. Maybe worse. ■

Rimi B. Chatterjee

TRIP DOWN GHOST LANE

Rich characters and themes drive this intense tale by Shahidul Zahir about post-independence Bangladesh

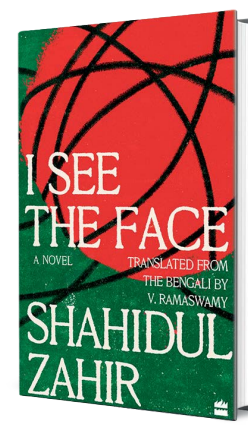
IT seemed that in the Ghost Lane of Old Dhaka, rumour and reality mirrored each other more often than they should. In fact, it's this mixture that's the tour de force of Shahidul Zahir's book *I See The Face*, and which fuels the characters across gender, age, nationality, and class.

In Ghost Lane, several spectres haunted its residents—for Chan Miya, who had been the talk of the town since he was born 'out of a bundle' and raised by monkeys, the spectre of his abusive childhood haunted him. For his mother, Khoimon, the spectre of poverty borne out of selling paper bags for a living and trading monkey-gossip for food. And for Mrs Zobeida Rahman, the spectre of Khoimon's shrewdness itself.

Most of the novel revolves around three childhood friends who drifted apart gradually: Mamun al Hye, Fakhrul Alam Ledu, and Chan Miya. Among the three, Chan Miya was bullied in school and eventually dropped out because of his association with monkeys and being a fatherless son of a destitute mother. The novel shows a deep class divide that scorns at Khoimon for sending her child to a school that had well-off children.

Despite her efforts, Chan Miya became a car thief and remained in perpetual fear of being caught, but was equally thrilled with every car he stole. Another perspective in the novel is that of Anglo-Indian Mrs Mary Clark and her daughter Julie Florence. Even though they have spent their whole lives in Dhaka, they still grapple with an identity crisis and imposed alienation that propels young Julie to narrow down her marriage prospects. Mamun, Ledu, and Chan Miya were all taught by Mrs Mary Clark in their primary classes, and the bond sustained as the three grew up. Even though the destinies of the three boys followed paths that were as different as they could be, one thing was common: all of them were smitten by Julie Florence and cooked up romantic stories in their heads imagining her.

The structure of the novel shows its utmost fidelity to the rumours of Ghost Lane. Many alternate realities separated by an occasional 'perhaps' drive the narratives. The possibilities that a single event can contain are all



I SEE THE FACE
by Shahidul Zahir; translated from Bengali by V. Ramaswamy
HARPERCOLLINS
₹499; 256 pages

written in an enthusiastic detective vein by Zahir. If the story of Chan Miya being the 'Monkey Boy' adds humour and realism to the novel, then the story of Mamun dispenses suspense and mystery. The author portrays post-independence Bangladesh interspersed with Bangladesh's history, the 1971 Liberation War, in a form that echoes the culture of oral storytelling as well as of epic writing. ■

Saleem Rashid Shah